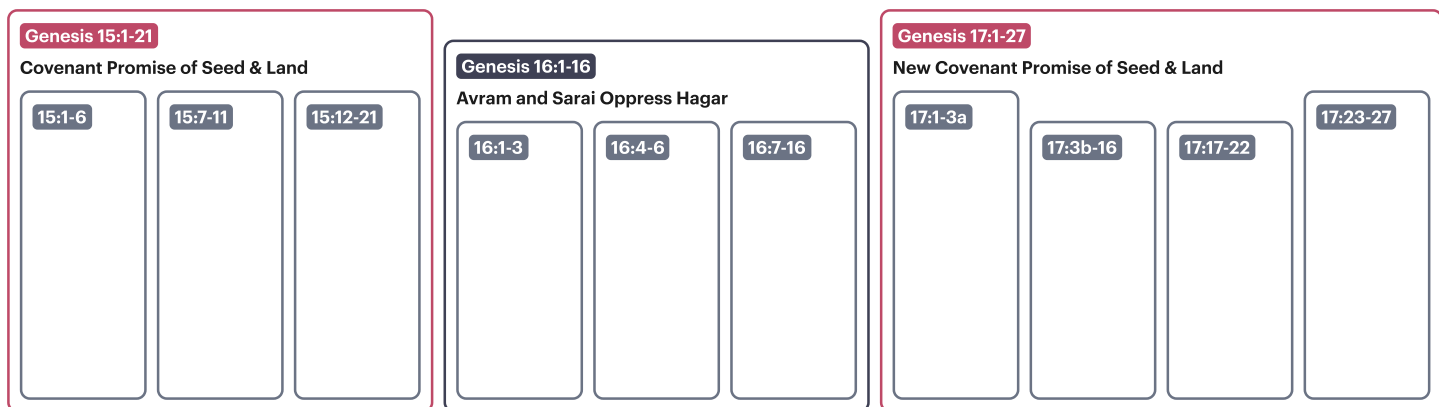


Session 12: Seed Like Stars

Key Takeaways

- Like the human in the garden, Avram is naked with only God as his source of delivering help.
- God credits Avram as righteous—in right relationship—when Avram ceases his scheming and simply trusts God’s promise.
- God’s promise to make Avram’s descendants like the stars evokes both their vast quantity and glorious destiny.

Macro Design of Genesis 15-17



Genesis 15:1-17:27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 15

- God’s first promise to Avram
 - “Don’t be afraid Avram,
I am your deliverer,
your very numerous (הרבה מאד) reward.”
- Avram’s belief and unbelief → God makes a covenant

Genesis 16

- Avram and Sarai’s failure to believe in God’s promise
- They abuse Hagar in order to produce seed

Genesis 17

- God's renewed promise to Avram
 - “Walk before me and be blameless!
I will make my covenant with you
and **make you very numerous**(אָרְבֶּה ... מְאֹד)
- Avram's belief and unbelief → God renews the covenant **with a sign: circumcision**

Genesis 15:1-17:27 (Repeated Words). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

In this section, the focus of the narrative turns to God's promise of the seed and Avram and Sarai's failure to trust God's generosity. Notice the symmetrical design that highlights the role of God's covenant with Avram. The sequence of the three stories is significant.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 15:1-21

Yahweh Makes a First Promise of Protection and Reward

¹ After these things,
the word of Yahweh was to Avram in a vision, **saying** :
 “Don't be afraid, Avram!
 I am a delivering-shield for you.
 Your reward is great, very much!”

Avram Responds With a Doubt-Filled Question

a ² **And Avram said** ,
 b “ **Master Yahweh, what will you give to me** ?
Now, I am going on naked/without children
 c **and a son of Mesheq of my house** [this is Damascus] **is Eliezer**.

Avram Responds With His Own Plan

a' ³ **And Avram said** ,
 b' “ **Look at me! You have given to me no seed** ,
 c' **and so look! A son of my house will inherit me!**”

Yahweh Makes a Second Promise of a Son

⁴ And look! **The word of Yahweh was to Avram, saying** :
 a “This one will not **inherit** you.
 b Rather, one who comes out from your innards,
 a that one will **inherit** you.”

Yahweh Speaks

⁵ And he brought him outside,

and he said :

“Stare, please, at the skies,
and **count** the stars,
if you are able to **count** them.”

Yahweh Speaks a Promise of Abundant Seed

And he said to him :

“Such will be your **seed**.”

Avram Responds: Trust and Righteousness

⁶ And he trusted in Yahweh,
and he attributed this to him as right-relationship.

Yahweh Makes a Third Promise of Land

- a ⁷ **And he said to him** ,
b “I am Yahweh, who brought you out from Ur of Kasdim,
to give to you this land, to **inherit** it.”

Avram Responds With a Doubt-Filled Question

- a' ⁸ **And he said** ,
b' “ **Master Yahweh, with what can I know** that I will **inherit** it?”

Yahweh Orders Avram To Get Animals

- ⁹ **And he said to him** ,
“ **Take** for me a three year old calf,
and a three year old goat,
and a three year old ram,
and a dove and a pigeon.”

Avram Obeys and Gets Animals

- ¹⁰ And he **took** for himself **all of these**,
and he **halved** (ויבתר) them in the middle,
and he set each **half** (בתרו) so it met its neighbor,
and the **birds** he did not **halve** (בתר).
¹¹ And **birds of prey** came down upon the corpses,
and Avram blew at them.

- a 12 **And as the sun was going** ,
 b then a **deep-stupor-sleep** **fell upon Avram** ,
 b' and look: **a terror, a darkness** , a great one, **fell upon him** .

- 13 And **he said to Avram** ,
 a "You must know that your **seed** will be immigrants in **a land** not their own,
 and they will **serve** them,
 and they will **oppress** them for **four hundred years** ;
 b 14 and also, **that nation** which they **serve**, I will judge,
 and after that, they will go out with great possessions.
 15 And as for you, you will go to your fathers,
 in completeness you will be buried, at a good old age.
 a' 16 And **the fourth generation** will return here,
 because the crookedness of the **Amorite** isn't complete unto here."

- a 17 **And the sun was going** ,
 b and there was **gloomy darkness** ,
 b' and look: **a furnace of smoke and fiery flame**
 that was passing in between these pieces.

- 18 On that day, **Yahweh cut a covenant (ברית)** with **Avram, saying** :
 a " **To your seed** **I have given this land** ,
 b from the river of **Egypt** unto the great river Euphrates,
 a' 19 along with the Cainite, and the Qenizzite, and the Qadmonite
 a" 20 and the Hittite, and the Perizzite, and the Rephaim
 a"' 21 and the **Amorite** , and the Canaanite, and the Girgashite, and the Jebusite.

Genesis 15:1-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Promise of Seed and Land

There is an important progression in this chapter as it unfolds in a sequence of dialogues between Yahweh and Avram that lead up to the making of the covenant.

Scene 1: A Dialogue About Seed (Genesis 15:1-6)

1. The first dialogue (Gen. 15:1-3)

- **Yahweh's promise about reward**
- **Avram responds with doubt**

Scene 2: A Dialogue About Land (Genesis 15:7-21)

1. The first dialogue (Gen. 15:7-11)

- **Yahweh's promise about land**

Dialogue About Seed and Land. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Scene 1: A Dialogue About Seed (Genesis 15:1-6)	Scene 2: A Dialogue About Land (Genesis 15:7-21)
	• Avram responds with doubt • Yahweh takes Avram outside at night
2. The second dialogue (Gen. 15:4-6) • Yahweh's promise about seed • Yahweh takes Avram outside at night • Avram responds with trust • Yahweh considers him righteous	2. The second dialogue (Gen. 15:12-21) • Yahweh's promise about seed and land • Avram cannot respond (he's passed out!) • Yahweh makes a covenant
Faith → Right-standing with Yahweh	Doubt → Covenant
Dialogue About Seed and Land. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Notice how both scenes follow a parallel progression. Scene 1 focuses on Yahweh's promise of future seed for Avram. This seems ridiculous, so Avram not only questions how Yahweh could do this, but he also proposes his own alternate plan. Yahweh's response is to take him outside at night and repeat the promise. This scene closes positively, with Avram finally trusting Yahweh's promise, resulting in Avram's "right relational standing" with Yahweh.

Scene 2 focuses on Yahweh's promise of a land for Avram's future seed. This also seems ridiculous, so Avram again questions how Yahweh will pull this off. Yahweh again takes Avram outside and engages him in an ancient covenant ritual where Avram passes out and does not pass between the animal pieces. It's as if Avram's continued lack of trust (with the brief exception of Gen. 15:6) compels Yahweh to do something more drastic that will make his promise formal and concrete: He will make a covenant. While the covenant is positive in one sense, when we contrast scenes 1 and 2, we can't help but feel that something has been lost. Avram's radical trust in the promise of God results in righteousness, whereas his doubt leads to a covenant. No longer does God's promise rest on his word, but on the basis of a sacrifice and oath of loyalty that formalizes the relationship. This is a similar portrayal of the covenant to what we find in Genesis 8-9, where the covenant is a ceasefire mechanism that is positive but not ideal.

The Re-Creation of Avram After the Flood of Kings

Just as Noah emerged from the ark and received God's blessing and a covenant after his sacrifice, so now Avram emerges from the flood of the kings, and he receives a blessing in Jerusalem over a sacrificial meal.

Noah After the Flood	Avram After the Battle
Gen. 8 • Noah emerges safely from the flood onto a mountain • On the high place of Ararat, Noah offers a sacrifice • God blesses Noah	Gen. 14 • Avram emerges safely from the flood onto a mountain • On the high place, Avram gives up the plunder • Melchizedek gives God's blessing to Avram
Gen. 9 God makes a covenant with Noah	Gen. 15 God makes a covenant with Avram
Recreation of Avram After the Flood. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Links Between Genesis 14 and 15

While there appears to be little connection between these two chapters, there are in fact many deep links between the stories. Many consist of subtle wordplays and hyperlinks.

Genesis 14	Genesis 15
Gen. 14:20 “Blessed be El-Elyon, who delivered (מגן) your enemies into your hand.”	Gen. 15:1 “Don’t be afraid, Avram, I am your shield (מגן), and your great reward (שכר)”
Gen. 14:21 “Give me the people and take the plunder (רכש) for yourself!”	
Gen. 14:15 And [Avram] struck them and chased them unto Khovah, which is north of Damascus (דמשק).	Gen. 15:2 “But I am exposed, and a son of Mesheq (משק) of my house [this is Damascus (דמשק)], Eliezer is my heir.”
Gen. 14:14 And [Avram] rallied his dedicated men, those born into his house, three hundred and eighteen ...	Gen. 15:2 “Eliezer” (אליעזר) = 318 in Hebrew numbers
Gen. 14:5 the Rephaim	Gen. 15:16 the sin of the Amorite
Gen. 14:7 the Amorites	Gen. 15:20-21 and the Rephaim ... and the Amorite
Links Between Genesis 14 and 15. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

These hyperlinks show that [Genesis 15](#) is in fact the thematic continuation of [Genesis 14](#).

God's First Speech: Reward and Protection

Genesis 15:1b Instructor's Translation

Don't be afraid, Avram!
I am a delivering-shield for you.
Your reward is great, very much!

God's opening words are the direct response to the events of chapter 14.

- "a delivering shield"—Avram just declared war on an alliance of Mesopotamian kings.
- "your reward"—Avram just forfeited all of the war plunder in an act of trust in God's blessing.

Avram's response, then, is a perfectly reasonable one. He has been acting on the assumption that he would begin having children with Sarai to build a family that could inherit the land. So far, they have no biological children, and the only heir he has was a guy from Damascus, Eliezer.

Avram, Noah, and Adam and Eve

Just as Noah emerged from the flood and was blessed by God and invited into a covenant, this story is also interacting with a more distant thematic parallel: the garden of Eden stories.

Avram in Hebron: Genesis 15

Genesis 15:2 Instructor's Translation

I am going on exposed (עירי),
and a son of Mesheq of my house, is Eliezer (אליעזר)
Look, you have not given me any seed (זרע)

- Avram divides the animals in half and lays them down (15:10-11).
- God sends a "deep sleep" (תרדמה) that falls (נפל) upon Avram (15:12).

Adam and Eve in the Garden: Genesis 2

- The human is naked (ערום, 2:25).
- "It is not good that the human is alone, I will make a delivering-help (עזר) counterpart to him" (2:18).
- God sends a "deep sleep" (תרדמה) that falls (נפל) upon the human (2:21).
- God divides the human in half, taking one of his sides, from which God builds a woman (2:22).

Both stories are about how humans, by their own resources, cannot fulfill the calling that God has placed upon them. This impossibility requires trust in the divine promise to provide "delivering-help" (עזר). To emphasize that the humans are powerless to do what God requires of them, the "deep sleep" becomes an image of their helplessness and total dependence upon God's plan and power.

For Adam, the deliverance is עזר/ezer, for Avram the deliverance is זרע/zera'.

Trust and Right Relationship With God

This is an important moment in the Avraham narrative, and it's the first occurrence of the word "trust/believe" in the biblical story.

Trust

Hebrew *'amen* (אָמֵן) or *ne'eman* (נְאֻמָּן) = "to be true, trustworthy"

- "their water will be trustworthy" (i.e., reliable and continuous, [Isa. 33:16](#))
- "let your words be proven trustworthy" (i.e., true and reliable, [Gen. 42:20](#))
- "your house and your throne will be trustworthy" (i.e., enduring and reliable, [2 Sam. 7:16](#))

Hebrew *he'emin* (הֶאֱמִין) = "to consider someone trustworthy, to trust/believe"

- "The gullible consider anything believable/trustworthy" ([Prov. 14:15](#))
- "Jacob did not consider their words trustworthy/true" ([Gen. 45:26](#))

In this moment, Avram considers God's promise of a huge family with innumerable descendants to be a reliable, trustworthy promise. Notice he doesn't just "trust in" the word; he trusts in *Elohim* himself.

Righteousness

In Hebrew, righteousness (*tsedakah*, צְדָקָה) refers to a standard of right relationship: actions that create and maintain healthy, whole, and equitable relationships between two parties.

For example, when Yaaqov's (Jacob's) fair management of Laban's flocks is to be inspected, he says "my *tsedakah* will testify on my behalf, when you check on the flocks" ([Gen. 30:33](#)).

Jeremiah 22:3 Instructor's Translation

Do justice and *tsedakah*, by rescuing those robbed from the hand of their oppressor.

Genesis 38:26 Instructor's Translation

[Tamar] has shown more *tsadeqah* (verb) than I have, because I didn't give her to my son as a wife.

Job 29:14-17 NIV*

¹⁴ I put on *tsedeq* as my clothing; justice was my robe and my turban. ¹⁵ I was eyes to the blind and feet to the lame. ¹⁶ I was a father to the needy; I took up the case of the stranger. ¹⁷ I broke the fangs of the wicked and snatched the victims from their teeth.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"In order for an individual to be righteous, it means that of necessity he or she must exist and live in a manner which allows him or her to respond correctly in the values of the relationship (spouse, parent, judge, neighbor, etc.) ... In essence 'righteousness' is not simply an objective norm which is present within a society and which must be kept, but rather it is a concept which derives its meaning from the relationship

in which it finds itself. Right judging, right governing, right worshipping, and generosity are all covenantal activities and so righteous, despite their diversity.”

Gossai, Hemchand (1993). [*Justice, Righteousness and the Social Critique of the Eighth-Century Prophets*](#). Peter Lang. 55-56.

In this story, Avram’s trust in God’s promise is considered by God to be an act of “doing right by” him.

Reflection Question

Beyond sheer quantity, what significance do stars have in the Hebrew Bible?